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Consumer Reports Endorses Bill That Aims to Protect California Kids From Ultra-Processed Food in Schools

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YONKERS, New York, March 20 -- Consumer Reports posted the following news release:

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Consumer Reports endorses bill that aims to protect California kids from ultra-processed food in schools

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel's bill directs California to identify harmful ultra-processed foods to be phased out of schools

SACRAMENTO, CA - Under a bill by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, the California Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment (OEHHA) would be required to define ultra-processed foods and identify harmful ones to phase out of California public schools by 2032. Consumer Reports is co-sponsoring the legislation along with the Environmental Working Group.

Recent research has linked diets that include a lot of ultra-processed foods -- such as soft drinks, instant soups, and packaged snacks -- to an increased risk of obesity, high blood pressure, irritable bowel syndrome, heart disease and even cancer. An estimated 67 percent of the calories in food eaten by children, according to a study published in JAMA in 2021.

"The typical diet for most kids is made up of far too much ultra-processed food that can put their health at risk," said Brian Ronholm, director of food policy at Consumer Reports. "Our schools can play an important role in ensuring kids have healthier food options instead of contributing to unhealthy eating habits."

Ronholm continued, "Assemblymember Gabriel's landmark bill will protect children and establish an important new standard for the rest of the country by getting harmful ultra-processed food out of our schools."

The bill defines ultra-processed foods as those that contain one or more certain functional ingredients, including colors, flavors, sweeteners, emulsifiers, and thickening agents. OEHHA would be required to identify ultra-processed foods considered particularly harmful based on whether peer-reviewed evidence has linked the substance to cancer, cardiovascular disease, metabolic disease, developmental harms, reproductive harms, obesity, Type 2 diabetes; whether the substance is hyper-palatable or may contribute to food addiction; and whether the food has been modified to be high in fat, sugar and salt.

Assemblymember Gabriel previously authored and passed the California School Food Safety Act, which banned six harmful dyes in food served in the state's public schools. Prior to that, Gabriel introduced and passed the California Food Safety Act, which banned four harmful chemicals from candy, cereal, soda and other processed food sold in the state. CR and EWG co-sponsored both bills.

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JOURNAL: JAMA https://www.ama-assn.org/delivering-care/public-health/what-doctors-wish-patients-knew-about-ultraprocessed-foods

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Original text here: https://advocacy.consumerreports.org/press_release/consumer-reports-endorses-bill-that-aims-to-protect-california-kids-from-ultra-processed-food-in-schools/

[Category: Business]

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